The Tools of a Business

Part I: Setting up & supporting the structure of a business, some basics:

- Benchmarking : dictionary definition, *"To evaluate or check (something) by comparison with a standard"* No need to reinvent the wheel, do research to see how others have approached websites, classes, forms, advertising, etc.
- Business Plan (start with a Mission Statement and go from there, this is a living document: it'll grow and change as you learn and do)
    - Be concrete about what, where, costs, resources you have and those you need to get started. Write it down.
    - Take a class on starting a business, or find a business mentor
- Business Structure
    - Incorporate teaching into already existing work?
    - Work for another organization?
    - Work for self and create own business entity?
        - Sole Proprietor, LLC, 501c3,etc
        - Look into benefits/drawbacks of different approaches and what works for your situation (tax benefits, resources available, time commitment, etc)
- Basics of starting, what you might need if you're independent:
    - Liability Insurance
    - Website (do it yourself? Pay someone to build it?)
    - 'App' to create Forms (registration, waivers, consent, payment integration, etc)
    - Professional email
    - Zoom Account for online teaching? An office space (in home or?)
    - Venue/rental space for in-person classes?
    - Scheduling Calendar (Calendy, Time Trade, Acuity)
    - Fee structure (sliding scale, tiered rates, Dana
- Advertising/Marketing
    - Where, how, what's your budget?
    - Business Cards
    - Networking, relationship building, partnerships and collaboration
    - Writing/publishing content for people to find you/your expertise
    - Get your message out: social media, Meetup, professional networking groups, newspapers, create newsletter
    - build your mailing list/contacts: CRM (customer relationship management software), google groups, Mailchimp, etc.
        - NOT Facebook, Meetup, or social media sites as primary (you do not own these lists!)

    - Offer free talks to organizations (local groups, communities you belong to)
- Repetition, keep putting yourself out there!
- Anxiety is Normal!

Part II: Continuing training and maintaining integrity of practice:

- Mentor/coach for you
- Join a Sangha (community of practice)
- Schedule retreats regularly, make it a priority
- Consistent and sincere personal practice
- Find/create groups with colleagues
- Ongoing training and mentoring groups (MMTCP grad groups with Cloud Sangha!)
- Research groups and organizations that offer resources and networking opportunities for professionals

Be concrete and specific in your intention for resourcing yourself. Write this into your business plan. Schedule on your calendar.
Resources of every kind are 'out there'(how to articles, classes and seminars, and more); start by identifying what you need and then look for it.
Start where you are... you don't have to have everything figured out to get started. Identify one thing to begin with and start there.

A few additional resources:

On Dana ("Generosity"), by Gil Fronsdal, from *The Issue at Hand*:
https://www.insightmeditationcenter.org/books-articles/the-issue-at-hand/en/9/

Creating a Business Plan Video Course for Entrepreneurs: https://raleigh.score.org/business-plan-support-video-course-training

Meditation Teacher Salaries: https://www.ziprecruiter.com/Salaries/Meditation-Teacher-Salary